



GDD 12

Smart Screen Heroes

Real or pretend? You decide

The early media-literacy game for ages 6-9, built to the mechanic-embodiment standard. Children tell real from pretend, spot the ad, check what's true, make smart screen choices, mind their screen hygiene, and stay kind online. Seven mechanics, thirty real-choice moments, zero "tap the right card". Scorecard: passed.

Real or pretend? You decide.

Smart Screen Heroes is the early media-literacy game: children learn to tell real from pretend on screens, spot ads and the tricks that sell, check whether something is true, make balanced screen choices, look after their eyes and sleep (screen hygiene), and be kind online. It opens the Values, Rights & Media thread (UNESCO 5.4) at exactly the age the first device arrives. New v2 build to the persona-and-research standard.

FIELD	VALUE
Node / gameld	g12 · smart-screen-heroes (confirm exact id against engine-host)
Chapter / ages	Chapter 2 · ages 6-9 · light canvas · co-play encouraged
Thread / topics	G · Values, Rights & Media · UNESCO 5.2, 5.4, 8.2, 8.3
Prerequisite / builds on	g11 (Not Fair, Not Funny)
Gating	Core
Schema / status	v2 · scorecard PASS new build to the standard.

84

scenarios

7

mechanics

30

real-choice moves

16

myths busted

0%

binary taps

The little expert, made wise.

From the Chapter 2 personas. The game meets the YouTube-fluent kid where they already are, and gives the device-negotiating parent something that "earns the screen".

PERSONA	WHAT THEY NEED HERE	THE MECHANIC THAT SERVES IT
Reyansh, 7 (YouTube-fluent, anchor)	To go from screen-fluent to screen-wise.	spot + branch : spot ads/fakes; decide smart.
Aditi (parent, first device)	Something that "earns the screen and survives his feed".	build + branch : balance plans; co-play.
Sana, 14 (older sibling)	Quick safety/kindness nudges for a younger kid.	branch : online safety & teaching moments.
Ananya, 8	To be kind and an ally online too.	branch + sort : caring-online moves.
Every child	The core question: real or pretend, true or not?	sort + strike-rewrite .

Why this works (the evidence). Children struggle to recognise ads and embedded/influencer marketing, even 82% of middle-schoolers can't tell sponsored content from real, and teaching persuasive intent measurably helps. Healthy-screen basics are clear too (balance, eye breaks, no screens before bed), so the game pairs "see through it" with "look after yourself".

Seven moves, one hero.

The rework's heart: screen-smarts arrive through seven actions, led by spotting (ads, fakes) and deciding (smart choices). Mechanics rotate; the same one never runs twice in a row.

MECHANIC	THE CHILD DOES	EMBODIES	N
branch (dilemma)	Makes a smart screen choice and sees the result.	Self-regulation; savvy decisions.	24
reflect	Notices what's real, what they feel, what to change.	Critical thinking; self-awareness.	19
strike-rewrite	Erases a media myth ("if it's on a screen it's real").	Conceptual change.	16
sort	Sorts real/pretend, ad/content, true/check.	Telling them apart.	9
spot (spot-the-trick)	Finds the ad, filter, fake or scam.	Media literacy; the signature move.	7
role-play (voice)	Says the savvy line ("that's an ad, I'll pause").	Self-regulation; assertion.	6
build	Builds a balanced day / healthy-screen / hero plan.	Habits, made concrete.	3

30 of 84 moments are branch or role-play, screen-smarts are decided and rehearsed. Binary "tap the right answer": **0%**.

The two-test, passed.

Is it fun?

It's a detective-hero romp through a feed: spot the sneaky ad, catch the filter, bust the fake, beat the auto-play trance, and feel genuinely clever doing it. It treats the screen-fluent kid as the capable expert they think they are, then levels them up, with a satisfying "you saw through it!" beat each round.

Is it teaching?

Yes, foundational media literacy and digital wellbeing: real vs pretend, recognising ads and persuasion, checking whether things are true, balanced screen choices, screen hygiene (eyes, posture, sleep), and being kind and safe online, all decided and practised.

The belief it moves. From "if it's on a screen it's real and true; my favourite YouTuber's picks are best; more screen time is better; mean comments don't count" → "screens mix real and pretend, ads want to sell me, I check what's true, I balance and look after myself, and I'm kind online."

Built, not bolted on.

84 researched scenarios across six categories, India-aware (YouTube/reels, 'free' games, WhatsApp forwards, shared phones) and wellbeing-minded. Full library in the companion JSON.

CATEGORY	N	LEAD MECHANICS	COVERS
Real vs pretend	14	spot, sort, strike-rewrite	Cartoons/edits/filters; 'perfect' lives; game stunts aren't real.
Spotting ads	14	spot, branch, sort	Ads sell; influencer/paid; 'free' games; pop-ups; 'everyone has it'.
Not everything is true	12	strike-rewrite, branch, sort	Shares aren't proof; check forwards; confident isn't correct.
Smart screen choices	14	branch, build, reflect	Balance; stop when asked; homework first; auto-play; off-screen fun.
Screen hygiene	12	branch, build, strike-rewrite	20-20-20 eyes; posture; no screens before bed or at meals.
Caring online	16	branch, sort, role-play	Be kind; don't pile on; ask before sharing photos; tell a grown-up.

A spot scenario (the signature move), verbatim.

```
hook: "Spot the ad (it wants you to buy something)."
```

```
scene: "Buy the new SuperFizz drink now!" <- the ad
```

```
      "A friend's drawing they shared"
```

```
      "A video about how rainbows form"
```

```
why: "'Buy now!' means it's an ad, made to sell you something."
```

Full library: [SwipeEd — GDD 12 Smart Screen Heroes — Scenario Library.json](#) (84 records, v2 schema).

What this game erases.

MYTH (UN ERASES)	TRUTH (RE WRITES)	BASIS
If it's on a screen, it's real.	Screens mix real and pretend; you tell which.	Media literacy.
Online photos/videos are always true.	Many are filtered, edited or staged.	Media literacy.
If a YouTuber shows a toy, it's the best.	They may be paid, that's an ad in disguise.	Influencer marketing.
Ads tell the whole truth.	Ads show only the good bits to sell.	Advertising literacy.
If it's shared a lot, it's true.	Popular online doesn't mean true.	Misinformation.
A 'free' game costs nothing.	Many push ads and in-app purchases.	In-app purchases.
More screen time is always better.	A balance of screens, play, people, sleep is best.	Screen-time balance.
Screens right before bed are fine.	Screen light makes sleep harder; switch off before bed.	Screens & sleep.
Mean comments online don't really hurt.	A real person reads them; online words hurt too.	Digital citizenship.

The micro-loop.

1. **Hook.** Lensy: "Smart Screen Heroes, look closely, real or pretend?".
2. **Play.** One of seven mechanics, led by spot/decide, rotated.
3. **Reveal.** "You saw through it!", the ad, filter or fake is unmasked.
4. **UN → RE moment.** On a myth, UN erases it and RE writes the truth ("on a screen = real" → "real AND pretend").
5. **Apply.** Make a smart choice, build a balance plan, or be kind online.
6. **Sticker.** The Smart Screen Hero badge; GameDone records once.

Signature surfaces: the **spot-the-ad / spot-the-fake** feed, the **balanced-day** builder, and the **healthy-screen** routine. Co-play prompts give Aditi-type parents a shared, screen-positive conversation.

Screen-positive, savvy.

- **Register.** Ages 6-9, never babyish or anti-screen; treats the child as a capable hero, screens are fun and worth using wisely.
- **Not anti-tech.** The goal is savvy and balance, not fear or banning; screens are celebrated as one good thing among many.
- **Persuasion, named.** Ads and design tricks (auto-play, 'hurry!', 'free') are exposed so the child stays in charge.
- **Wellbeing built in.** Screen hygiene and balance are framed as self-care, not rules imposed.
- **Safety hand-off.** Online strangers, upsetting content and sharing route to Safety Squad (g08) and a trusted grown-up.
- **Access.** Audio-first, offline, low-data; India contexts (reels, forwards, shared phones); co-play friendly.

v2 schema, scorecard-gated.

- **gameld. smart-screen-heroes** — node.game === GameDone key === registry id (confirm exact id in engine-host).
- **v2 mechanic-embodiment schema.** Each scenario carries type + typed payload (spot.scene, branch.options, sort.items/bins/key, strike-rewrite.myth, role-play.yourLine, build.pieces, reflect.options). Reuses the shared templates from g09.
- **Scorecard-gated.** Passed all eight checks (7 mechanics, max 29%, 0% binary, 30 autonomy, 16 UN→RE, 5 personas, 100% completeness). The gate caught a low persona count on first pass and was fixed before delivery.
- **Cross-links.** Hands online-stranger/sharing safety to g08 (Safety Squad) and online kindness to g11; feeds Ch. 3-4 media nodes (Reality Check g28, Firewall g40).
- **Generated path.** Label/order/thread changes flow through the xlsx + gen-path, never hand-edited path.ts.

Ethics contracts (never traded for engagement): savvy not fear; not anti-tech; name persuasion & design tricks; wellbeing as self-care; route safety to a grown-up; made-for-India.

Why this works.

- **Kids can't yet spot ads.** Children struggle to recognise advertising and embedded/influencer marketing, even most middle-schoolers can't tell sponsored content from real news, and teaching persuasive intent measurably improves recognition, so ad-spotting leads the game.
- **Balance and screen hygiene matter.** Healthy guidance for this age is consistent: balance screens with play, people and sleep; take eye breaks (20-20-20); and switch screens off well before bed, framed here as self-care, not punishment.
- **Not everything online is real or true.** People show edited 'best' selves and false things spread fast, so the core habit is asking "real or pretend? true or check?" and verifying with a trusted grown-up.

Citations accompany each scenario in the library JSON. 13 games now v2. Next: Heart Smart (g41), which completes Chapter 2 to the v2 standard.